SOCIAL PRISM SOCIOLOGY BY PATHAN MUSHEER KHAN

UPSC CSE SOCIOLOGY OPTIONAL — PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS (CHAPTER 4 COMPENDIUM)

CHAPTER 4: SOCIOLOGICAL THINKERS

A) KARL MARX — HISTORICAL MATERIALISM, MODE OF PRODUCTION, ALIENATION, CLASS STRUGGLE

YEAR	PAPER	Q.NO	MARKS	QUESTION STATEMENT
2026	I	6(b)	20	Critically analyse the mode of production debate from different perspectives [cite: 12].
2026	I	2(a)	20	Describe the impact of capitalist mode of production on society [cite: 12].
2025	I	2(b)	20	Highlight the main features of historical materialism as propounded by Marx. How far is this theory relevant in understanding contemporary societies? Explain [cite: 12].
2024	I	3(c)	10	Critically explain the salient features of 'alienation' as propounded by Karl Marx [cite: 12].
2023	I	2(b)	20	What is historical materialism? Examine its relevance in understanding contemporary societies [cite: 12].
2021	I	3(b)	20	Critically examine the dialectics involved in each mode of production as propounded by Karl Marx [cite: 12].
2020	I	7(c)	20	Critically assess the Marxian Theory of 'Alienation' [cite: 12].
2019	I	1(c)	10	What is the Marxist concept of 'Fetishism of Commodities'? [cite: 12]
2018	I	4(a)	20	According to Marx, how are human beings alienated from their human potential and what does he suggest to change this? [cite: 12]
2017	I	3(b)	20	Analyse Marxian conception of historical materialism as a critique of Hegelian dialectics [cite: 12].
2016	I	1(d)	10	Evaluate Marx's ideas on mode of production [cite: 12].
2014	I	2(b)	20	Identify the similarities and differences between Marx's theory of 'alienation' and Durkheim's theory of 'anomie' [cite: 12].
2014	I	7(c)	10	According to Marx, capitalism transforms even the personal relationship between men and women. Critically examine with illustrations from the contemporary Indian context [cite: 12].
2013	I	2(c)	20	Analyse the salient features of historical materialism [cite: 12].
2013	I	6(a)	20	How do Karl Marx and Max Weber differ in terms of their analysis of social stratification? [cite: 12]

B) EMILE DURKHEIM — DIVISION OF LABOUR, SOCIAL FACT, SUICIDE, RELIGION AND SOCIETY

YEAR	PAPER	Q.NO	MARKS	QUESTION STATEMENT
2026	I	3(c)	10	How does Emile Durkheim conceptualize religion as a 'social fact'? Explain [cite: 12].
2025	I	7(b)	20	How do Marx, Weber and Durkheim differ in understanding religion? Explain [cite: 12].
2024	I	5(a)	10	Describe various characteristics of a 'social fact'. How is rate of suicide a social fact according to Durkheim? [cite: 12]
2022	I	1(d)	10	Durkheim argued that society is more than the sum of individual acts. Discuss [cite: 12].
2022	I	3(b)	20	Critically examine how Durkheim and Merton explicate Anomie [cite: 12].
2022	I	5(a)	10	Critically examine the relevance of Durkheim's views on religion in contemporary society [cite: 12, 13].
2021	I	1(d)	10	Explain whether Durkheim's theory of Division of Labour is relevant in the present-day context [cite: 13].
2020	I	3(b)	20	Critically analyse Durkheim's views on elementary forms of religious life and role of religion. Also discuss the consequences of religious revivalism in contemporary society [cite: 13].
2020	I	5(c)	10	What are the problems in observing social facts in Durkheim's views? [cite: 13]
2019	I	5(e)	10	How well do you think Tonnies, Durkheim, Weber and Marx predicted the character of modern society? Critique [cite: 13].
2018	I	2(b)	20	Explain Durkheim's basic arguments on suicide. Can you analyse high suicide rates of contemporary Indian society with Durkheim's theory? [cite: 13]
2018	I	8(c)	20	In what way did Durkheim perceive religion as functional to society? [cite: 13]
2017	I	3(c)	20	Discuss distinct sociological method adopted by Emile Durkheim in his method of 'suicide' [cite: 13].
2015	I	8(c)	20	Elaborate the views of Durkheim on "The Elementary Forms of Religious Life" [cite: 13].
2014	I	5(e)	10	"According to Durkheim, the essence of religion in modern society is the same as religion in primitive society." Comment [cite: 13].
2013	I	3(a)	20	Compare Karl Marx with Emile Durkheim with reference to the framework of 'division of labour' [cite: 12, 13].

C) MAX WEBER — SOCIAL ACTION, IDEAL TYPES, AUTHORITY, BUREAUCRACY, PROTESTANT ETHIC

YEAR	PAPER	Q.NO	MARKS	QUESTION STATEMENT
2026	I	5(d)	10	How does Max Weber's 'theory of authority' shape bureaucracy? Analyse [cite: 13].
2025	I	5(d)	10	How does Weber's Verstehen address the objectivity-subjectivity debate in sociology? [cite: 13]
2024	I	3(b)	20	Describe the main idea of Max Weber's book, 'The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism' as a critique of Marxism [cite: 13].
2021	I	3(c)	20	Do you agree with Max Weber's idea that bureaucracy has the potential to become an iron cage? Justify your answer [cite: 13].
2020	I	1(d)	10	'Ideal Types' of Max Weber are mental constructs; they do not correspond to the reality. Give your views [cite: 13].
2019	I	3(a)	20	Discuss the importance of interpretative understanding of social phenomena and explain its limitations [cite: 13].
2018	I	1(b)	10	Distinguish between fact and value in Weber's Protestant Ethic and Spirit of Capitalism [cite: 13].
2016	I	4(a)	20	Examine Max Weber's method of maintaining objectivity in social research [cite: 13].
2015	I	1(d)	10	Which concept did Weber use to analyse the forms of legitimate domination? [cite: 13]
2014	I	4(a)	20	How does Weber use the notion of 'ideal types' in his theory of bureaucracy? [cite: 13]
2013	I	3(c)	10	Examine the salient features of Weberian bureaucracy [cite: 13].

D) TALCOTT PARSONS — SOCIAL SYSTEM, PATTERN VARIABLES

YEAR	PAPER	Q.NO	MARKS	QUESTION STATEMENT
2022	I	7(a)	20	Critically analyse Parsons views on society as a social system [cite: 14].
2020	I	1(e)	10	Analyse the relevance of 'Pattern Variables' in the study of Social change [cite: 14].
2018	I	7(a)	20	How can Parsons AGIL framework be used to analyse key problems in a society? Discuss [cite: 14].
2017	I	1(d)	10	Critically analyse Talcott Parsons' conception 'Pattern Variables' [cite: 14].
2016	I	2(b)	20	Describe the functional prerequisites of social systems as given by Talcott Parsons. Examine in the context of a university as a social system [cite: 14].
2015	I	4(b)	20	How is social equilibrium mentioned in Parsonian framework? [cite: 14]
2013	I	6(c)	20	Examine the relevance of Parsonian Social systems in a present society? [cite: 14]

E) ROBERT K. MERTON — REFERENCE GROUP, ANOMIE, MANIFEST & LATENT FUNCTIONS

YEAR	PAPER	Q.NO	MARKS	QUESTION STATEMENT
2025	I	1(d)	10	Can Merton's reference group theory be relevant in understanding 'identity making' in digital world? Explain [cite: 14].
2023	I	1(d)	10	Is reference group theory a universally applicable model? Elucidate [cite: 14].
2021	I	4(c)	20	With suitable examples, explain how conformity and deviance coexist in a society as propounded by R.K. Merton [cite: 14].
2020	I	2(a)	20	What are the reactions of R.K. Merton to the functionalism of social anthropologists? Bring on the limitations of latent functions [cite: 14].
2019	I	3(c)	10	What according to Merton, is the difference between 'unanticipated consequences' and 'latent functions'? Give examples to elaborate [cite: 14].
2019	I	8(b)	20	How according to Merton, are deviant subcultures generated? [cite: 14]

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2018	I	2(c)	10	What is the difference between the anomia in Merton and Durkheim? Explain [cite: 14].
2016	I	3(a)	20	Analyse the manifest and latent functions of 'security of the tenure of the bureaucrats' in the light of Merton's Theory [cite: 14].
2015	I	4(c)	20	"Anomie and the Social structure." Explain with reference to R.K. Merton's contribution [cite: 14].
2014	I	1(e)	10	How can we use reference group theory to understand the fashion in Society? [cite: 14]
2014	I	2(c)	10	How could one use Merton's concept of deviance to understand the traffic problems in urban area? [cite: 14]
2014	I	3(c)	10	Using Merton's Concept of 'manifest' and latent functions, explain the persistence of corruption in Indian Society [cite: 14].

F) G.H. MEAD — SELF AND IDENTITY

YEAR	PAPER	Q.NO	MARKS	QUESTION STATEMENT
2024	I	5(b)	10	Explain G.H. Mead's idea of development of 'self' through the 'generalized other' [cite: 14].
2022	I	6(a)	20	According to Mead the idea of self develops when the individual becomes self-conscious. Explain [cite: 14, 15].
2020	I	5(b)	10	Write short note: Mead's notion of self [cite: 15].
2019	I	2(a)	20	According to Mead, "We play a key role in our own socialisation." Explain [cite: 15].
2018	I	1(c)	10	Do you think 'I' and 'Me' are central terms in Mead's work? [cite: 15]
2015	I	2(c)	20	"Self and Society are twin-born." Examine the statement of Mead [cite: 15].
2014	I	4(c)	20	Using Mead's theory of symbolic interactionism, discuss the stages in the formation of gender identity [cite: 15].
2013	I	3(b)	20	Critically analyses the contributions of G.H. Mead to 'symbolic interactionism' [cite: 15].